

AOL lays off Netscape developers

In a move to reorganise its Open Source Mozilla browser team, America Online (AOL), laid off 50 employees involved in the Netscape Communications development subsidiary. Continuing support of current versions of Netscape and the Netscape Web portal is planned by the Company.

In an increasingly tough battle with Microsoft for browser market share, the lay-

offs mark the latest setback for Netscape. More than 90 per cent of Web surfers currently use Internet Explorer, according to site visitor statistics published by Google.

"Netscape remains a key part of our multi-brand strategy. 'We'll continue to support the browser and the portal,'" AOL spokesman Andrew Weinstein said.

The layoffs come as the



loose Mozilla.org group transforms itself into a non-profit foundation. Some of the new recruits are expected to come from Netscape's ranks.

However, a broad group of independent volunteers and staffers at other companies are expected to continue working on the open-source browser effort.

Nanotubes in screens

Motorola is working on a new display technology, using carbon nanotubes (CNT). Called the 'nano emissive display', the technology enables the manufacturers to produce large flat-panel displays at a lower cost. Motorola claims that the display quality will be better than that of plasma and LCD screens. If everything goes well, we could be seeing 50 to 80-inch CNT screens, costing the same as a 32-inch Cathode Ray screen.

It could also be used for producing much larger displays such as billboards. Carbon nanotubes can conduct electricity, withstand high temperatures, and are strong and light. These nanotubes, fire electrons at materials that emit light to produce colour displays. And scientists at Motorola Labs in Temple, Arizona have found a new way to grow nanotubes at low temperatures, which was

the only hurdle to its implementation. This is important because the substrate with which they must bond are heat sensitive. Research on carbon nanotubes has been going on for 10 years, and on this new process for about four years. The technology can be easily adapted to be used by plants that manufacture plasma screens. Carbon nano tubes can be used to produce a variety of other devices such as transistors, memory chips, batteries and sensors. The company is holding talks with European and Asian manufacturers to bring the product to the market.

Motorola had set up a factory in mid 90s in Temple to manufacture flat panel displays using microchip technology but the plant was closed in 2000 owing to certain technological problems. This time Motorola has promised there won't be a repeat act.



Commodore makes a comeback

Tulip Computers, owners of the Commodore brand, plan to re-launch due to an upsurge of interest in the obsolete Commodore 64 (C64) computer and its 1980s-era games. Tulip estimates that there are still 6 million Commodore users, who can choose from a range of 6,000 games which were developed for the system.

Hardware enthusiasts have written emulators for Windows PCs, Macintoshes, and now PocketPC-based PDAs to enable original Commodore games to run on those systems.



Tulip is working with Ironstone Partners, which will handle all sales of Commodore 64-related products worldwide and take over the main C64 Web portal. Tulip said that unauthorised use of the Commodore name by other organisations will soon be stopped.

Spot the hot spots sans the power

Ever been caught in a situation when the battery of your laptop is running low and you have to find a WiFi access point? Or when you are carrying your laptop in a bag? Every time you have to take out your laptop, wait for it to boot and check whether there is Wi-Fi coverage at that particular point. In all these cases, there has been the need for a device that could check availability of Wi-Fi coverage quickly and easily.



Kensington Technology Group (www.kensington.com), a manufacturer of a broad assortment of devices, has come up with a product called 'WiFi Finder'. The 2.95 x 0.39 x 2.17-inch, three

lights and only one button.

The button, of course, starts the search for the wireless LAN signal and if one is found, the lights will show its strength.

Kensington claims that its device is able to find 802.11b and 802.11g signals, if the hot-spot is up to 200 feet away. It also filters out other wireless signals such as Bluetooth. It is priced at about \$25, and comes with a 1-year warranty.

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